Incident Report — Overdue Invoice, Compromised Endpoint: Tracing a Finance Workstation Intrusion

SOC Analysis & Triage · Easy Operation

1. Header / Metadata

Operation ID	OPS-2026-0317-14
Operation name	Overdue Invoice, Compromised Endpoint (finance workstation intrusion)
Started (UTC)	2026-03-17 09:02:00
Closed (UTC)	2026-03-17 09:18:40
Analyst	Ndumiso Mbanjwa
Cohort	May26 Cybersecurity
Difficulty	Easy
Severity	Critical
Final verdict	True Positive
Status	Closed – Escalated for host isolation and reimage, credential reset, removal of the Run-key persistence and blocking of the C2

2. Executive Summary

A finance clerk at Brightwater Logistics, priya.venkataraman, was working through her inbox on the morning of 17 March 2026. Within seventeen minutes of one message arriving, her workstation bwl-fin-wks-042 was running PowerShell with hidden windows, had written a payload into a world-writable directory, had installed itself in the registry to survive a reboot, and was talking to an external server. The entire intrusion is visible in four records.

The lure was an overdue-invoice email from billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com — a domain that typosquats the company's own brightwater-logistics.com — carrying INVOICE_8841.zip. It failed both SPF and DMARC and the gateway delivered it anyway. Inside the archive was not an invoice but a Windows shortcut, INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk. At 09:11:48 powershell.exe started with explorer.exe as its parent, which is the signature of a user double-clicking a file rather than any scheduled or service activity. Its command line was deliberately obfuscated with caret escapes —

i^e^x and g^c, which Windows strips before execution to give IEX(Get-Content) — reading C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab. The .cab extension is a disguise: the file is a script being read line by line, not a cabinet archive, and it sits in a directory every user on the machine can write to.

Persistence came next. At 09:14:02 cmd.exe wrote a Run key under HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run named svchostno2, pointing at C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat. The name is chosen to be skimmed past in a list of startup entries — it imitates the legitimate Windows service host, and an analyst scrolling quickly may not register the "no2". Four minutes later, at 09:18:40, that same cmd.exe process reached out to https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php, resolving to 198.235.24.58 on port 443. This is a confirmed True Positive: all 6 scored tasks were resolved, and the platform classifies the pivot from delivery to execution as T1204.002.

3. Operation Details

Triggering detection	Mail gateway recorded delivery despite spf=fail and dmarc=fail (Medium); endpoint telemetry escalated to Critical on the registry write and the outbound connection
Source	billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com from src_ip 92.4.76.12; attacker infrastructure goosess[.]com (198.235.24.58)
Destination	https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php over TCP/443
User / Host affected	priya.venkataraman (finance clerk) on bwl-fin-wks-042; mail delivered through bwl-mail-01
Artefact	INVOICE_8841.zip → INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk → C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab (script) → C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat → Run key value svchostno2
Direction	Inbound phishing email with archive attachment; outbound HTTPS beacon from cmd.exe
Tool surfaces used	Security log platform (SIEM) and email gateway telemetry (EMAIL)

4. Investigation & Triage

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
Task 1 – Brief	Establish the question before opening the telemetry	The reported position: an accounts-payable workstation running programs it has	A single-host, single-hour investigation with a clear order to work in: what was delivered, what ran, what it left	Setting that order first prevents the common mistake of jumping to the network indicator and missing how the machine got there	Fig. 1

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
		no business running and reaching hosts unrelated to freight, with one hour of mail and endpoint records available	behind, and where it reported		
Task 2 – Establish what the message actually delivered	Identify the real attachment content	Mail gateway records for the clerk's mailbox on 17 March	09:02:00, Medium: MAIL-RECV from billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com (src_ip 92.4.76.12), subject “Outstanding Invoice #BUSAPOMKDS03 – payment overdue”, attachment INVOICE_8841.zip, spf=fail dmarc=fail, verdict=delivered. The archive contained INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk	The attachment name says invoice; the content is a Windows shortcut. A .lnk inside a ZIP is a delivery mechanism, not a document, and the sender domain typosquats the company's own	Fig. 1
Task 3 – Trace what the first stage put on disk	Recover the file the first stage wrote	Endpoint telemetry for bwl-fin-wks-042 between 08:58 and 09:12, including ScriptBlock logging (Event ID 4104)	09:11:48, High: powershell.exe (pid 7244), parent explorer.exe, cmdline “powershell.exe -w hidden -ep bypass -c $x='4859';i^e^x((g^c $env:public\UHCYb	Three tells in one line: -w hidden and -ep bypass, caret obfuscation resolving to IEX(Get-Content), and a script disguised with a .cab extension in a world-writable directory. Once it touches disk you	Fig. 1, 3

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig. ref
			G.cab))". The file written and then read is C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab	have a name and a path to hunt the rest of the estate with	
Task 4 – Pin down how the malware survives a reboot	Find the persistence mechanism	Registry telemetry for the same host in the minutes after execution	09:14:02, Critical: HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run\svchostno2 = "C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat", written by cmd.exe (pid 7640)	The answer is the value name svchostno2. It imitates the Windows service host so it survives a quick scan of startup entries, and it needs no administrator rights because HKCU belongs to the user	Fig. 2
Task 5 – Identify where the host phoned home	Establish the command-and-control destination	Network telemetry attributed to the process that wrote the persistence	09:18:40, Critical: cmd.exe (pid 7640) → https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php, resolved 198.235.24.58:443	Same pid 7640 that created the Run key, so persistence and beaconing belong to one process. A /read/get.php endpoint over 443 is a check-in, and the destination is the indicator to block and to sweep for	Fig. 2
Task 6 – Map the trigger to MITRE ATT&CK	Label the moment delivery became execution	The four records read in order, identifying the pivot point	T1204.002 User Execution: Malicious File — the clerk opened the archive and ran the shortcut, which is what started powershell.exe under explorer.exe	Everything before that point is delivery; everything after is the intrusion. Labelling the pivot correctly is what makes the case reusable after the domain and file names have rotated	Fig. 1, 2

5. Threat Intelligence

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
goosess[.]com	VirusTotal	11 of 89 vendors flagged it as malicious (ESET, Kaspersky, Fortinet, Lionic and VIPRE as Malware; BitDefender, G-Data, SOCRadar, Sophos as Phishing; alphaMountain and Forcepoint as Malicious). Categorised "phishing and fraud"; registrar GMO Internet Group (Onamae.com)	2026-09-19	The C2 endpoint contacted at 09:18:40 as https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php. External intelligence agrees with the endpoint telemetry, and the split between Malware and Phishing labels fits a loader domain that also fronts credential lures.
198.235.24.58	VirusTotal	12 of 89 vendors flagged it as malicious (Fortinet and Sophos as Malware; BitDefender, Certego, CyRadar, G-Data, SOCRadar, VIPRE as Phishing; Chong Lua Dao, Guardpot, IPsum, Lionic as Malicious). AS 396982 Google LLC, 198.235.24.0/24, US	2026-09-19	The resolution of goosess[.]com at the time of the beacon. Note the hosting: an address inside Google Cloud, which is why egress filtering by provider reputation alone would not have stopped this — the traffic looks like ordinary cloud-hosted HTTPS.
invoices-bwlogistics-pay[.]com	Internal telemetry	Sender domain; spf=fail and dmarc=fail at the	2026-03-17	A typosquat of the company's own brightwater-

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
		gateway, message still delivered		logistics.com. The authentication failures are the strongest signal available before any external lookup: the domain could not prove it was permitted to send as itself.
92.4.76.12	Internal telemetry	Source address recorded by the mail gateway for the delivering server	2026-03-17	Useful for correlating other deliveries from the same sending infrastructure across the mail estate.
UHCYbG.cab / 49120862.bat	Internal telemetry	Files staged in C:\Users\Public\ — a script disguised with a .cab extension, and the batch file referenced by the Run key	2026-03-17	Random-looking names in a world-writable directory. Both are hunting artefacts for the rest of the estate: the path is as much a finding as the file, since C:\Users\Public should never hold executable content.

This is assessed with high confidence as a commodity loader infection delivered by invoice-themed phishing: archive, shortcut, obfuscated PowerShell, staged script, registry persistence and an HTTPS check-in — a chain sold and reused by many operators rather than one identifiable group. External intelligence corroborates the network findings: both the C2 domain and its hosting address are flagged by a dozen vendors, split between malware and phishing labels. Two details are worth carrying forward. First, the C2 resolves into Google Cloud address space, so the beacon looks like ordinary cloud-hosted HTTPS and no provider-reputation rule would have stopped it. Second, none of that intelligence was needed to reach the verdict — authentication failure at the gateway, PowerShell spawned by explorer.exe, caret obfuscation, world-writable staging and an HKCU Run key were sufficient on their own, and all of them were available within seventeen minutes of delivery.

6. Timeline (UTC)

Time (UTC)	Event
2026-03-17 09:02:00	Medium — phishing email delivered from billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com with INVOICE_8841.zip; spf=fail, dmarc=fail, verdict=delivered (T1566.001)
2026-03-17 ~09:11	The clerk opens the archive and runs INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk (T1204.002)
2026-03-17 09:11:48	High — powershell.exe (pid 7244) starts with parent explorer.exe: -w hidden -ep bypass, caret-obfuscated IEX(Get-Content) against C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab (T1059.001, T1027)
2026-03-17 09:14:02	Critical — cmd.exe (pid 7640) writes HKCU Run value svchostno2 = C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat (T1547.001, T1036.005)
2026-03-17 09:18:40	Critical — cmd.exe (pid 7640) connects to https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php, resolved 198.235.24.58:443 (T1071.001)

7. Indicators of Compromise

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context
Email address	billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay[.]com	Sender of the lure; spf=fail, dmarc=fail, delivered anyway
Domain	invoices-bwlogistics-pay[.]com	Typosquat of brightwater-logistics.com used as the sender domain
IPv4	92.4.76.12	Source address of the delivering mail server
File name	INVOICE_8841.zip	Archive attachment carrying the shortcut
File name	INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk	Windows shortcut inside the archive — platform Confirmed finding
File path	C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab	Script staged in a world-writable directory and read by PowerShell — platform Confirmed finding
File path	C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat	Batch file referenced by the Run-key persistence
Registry value	HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run\svchostno2	Persistence masquerading as the Windows service host — platform Confirmed finding
Domain	goosess[.]com	C2 domain contacted for check-in — platform Confirmed finding; VirusTotal 11/89

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context
URL	https://goosess[.]com/read/get.php	Check-in endpoint over TCP/443
IPv4	198.235.24.58	Resolution of goosess[.]com at the time of connection; VirusTotal 12/89, hosted in Google Cloud
Host	bwl-fin-wks-042 (priya.venkataraman)	Compromised finance workstation

STIX 2.1 Bundle


```
{
    "type": "bundle",
    "id": "bundle--41efe9ff-3bdf-5cc2-b6b5-ec223023007c",
    "objects": [
        {
            "type": "identity",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Ndumiso Mbanjwa (May26 Cybersecurity)",
            "description": "SOC analyst incident report \u2014 May26 Cybersecurity cohort,
SOC Simulator operation Overdue Invoice, Compromised Endpoint: Tracing a Finance
Workstation Intrusion.",
            "identity_class": "individual",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "malware",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "LNK-to-PowerShell loader (Brightwater incident)",
            "description": "Commodity loader chain: ZIP archive containing a Windows
shortcut that launches obfuscated PowerShell, stages a script as UHCYbG.cab in
C:\\Users\\Public, installs an HKCU Run value named svchostno2 pointing at 49120862.bat,
and checks in to https://goosess.com/read/get.php.",
            "malware_types": [
                "downloader",
                "backdoor"
            ],
            "is_family": false,
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--5e060348-f1ca-56e4-864a-bcee0a12f016",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "User Execution: Malicious File",
```

```
            "description": "Platform-confirmed classification: the clerk opened the
archive and ran INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk, starting powershell.exe under explorer.exe.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1204/002/",
                    "external_id": "T1204.002"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "execution"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--7e28ede3-6f85-529a-976a-3a2dde7ec1df",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment",
            "description": "Invoice-themed message with INVOICE_8841.zip from a
typosquatted domain, delivered despite spf=fail and dmarc=fail.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1566/001/",
                    "external_id": "T1566.001"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "initial-access"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--d3186c23-ec14-5cf4-83bc-3030b59ab14b",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell",
            "description": "powershell.exe -w hidden -ep bypass executing IEX(Get-Content)
against the staged file.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
```

```
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1059/001/",
                    "external_id": "T1059.001"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "execution"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--17609a65-b597-5661-a45b-a5e2464bac06",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Obfuscated Files or Information",
            "description": "Caret-escaped command line (i^e^x, g^c) and a script disguised
with a .cab extension.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1027/",
                    "external_id": "T1027"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "defense-evasion"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--c53332c0-7265-5dba-860c-a2ff90ba3678",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Boot or Logon Autostart Execution: Registry Run Keys",
            "description": "HKCU Run value svchostno2 pointing at
C:\\Users\\Public\\49120862.bat.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1547/001/",
                    "external_id": "T1547.001"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
```

```
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "persistence"
                },
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "privilege-escalation"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--b0676e66-59ed-5936-80ac-2e94d445a570",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Masquerading: Match Legitimate Name or Location",
            "description": "Persistence value named to resemble the Windows service host
svchost.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1036/005/",
                    "external_id": "T1036.005"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "defense-evasion"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "attack-pattern",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "attack-pattern--a5e52405-94a2-540c-aca4-11ff96c767c4",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols",
            "description": "HTTPS check-in to https://goosess.com/read/get.php on port
443.",
            "external_references": [
                {
                    "source_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1071/001/",
                    "external_id": "T1071.001"
                }
            ],
            "kill_chain_phases": [
                {
```

```
                    "kill_chain_name": "mitre-attack",
                    "phase_name": "command-and-control"
                }
            ],
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--c34a6417-62a8-560e-9560-780a975e1eb2",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Phishing sender",
            "description": "Delivered 2026-03-17T09:02:00Z with attachment
INVOICE_8841.zip; spf=fail, dmarc=fail.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[email-addr:value = 'billing@invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--cd69a9d9-3389-5a61-b0ba-901fe92a28d2",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--c34a6417-62a8-560e-9560-780a975e1eb2",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--fbde28f2-a1e6-5811-9021-1c597cd95c66",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Typosquatted sender domain",
            "description": "Impersonates brightwater-logistics.com.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[domain-name:value = 'invoices-bwlogistics-pay.com']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
```

```
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--f38c071a-b6ab-5818-a779-29e44f5d20c7",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--fbde28f2-a1e6-5811-9021-1c597cd95c66",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--3b41da6c-f810-5efb-a753-62844e014d29",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Malicious shortcut",
            "description": "Windows shortcut inside INVOICE_8841.zip; executing it started
powershell.exe under explorer.exe.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[file:name = 'INVOICE#BUSAPOMKDS03.lnk']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--f2562308-5a15-5fbf-ae77-0ad263fe71a0",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--3b41da6c-f810-5efb-a753-62844e014d29",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--a7f864cd-4187-5822-be98-b84084e8bf25",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Staged first-stage script",
            "description": "Script staged at C:\\Users\\Public\\ and read via IEX(Get-
```

```
Content) at 2026-03-17T09:11:48Z.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[file:name = 'UHCYbG.cab']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--343bab99-5d45-5ca7-9ba8-47fffd87e9f5",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--a7f864cd-4187-5822-be98-b84084e8bf25",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--40bc10de-6e98-5619-b7e0-7c91a486fc5c",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Persistence payload",
            "description": "Referenced by HKCU Run value svchostno2, written 2026-03-
17T09:14:02Z.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[file:name = '49120862.bat']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--d1315402-a0e0-5596-a570-97f7f115b12d",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--40bc10de-6e98-5619-b7e0-7c91a486fc5c",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
```

```
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--ed0957d2-712d-5370-83a6-42e79f1fc0a9",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "Run key persistence",
            "description": "Autorun value masquerading as the Windows service host.",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[windows-registry-key:key =
'HKEY_CURRENT_USER\\\\Software\\\\Microsoft\\\\Windows\\\\CurrentVersion\\\\Run' AND
windows-registry-key:values[*].name = 'svchostno2']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--6297dd40-1de3-578f-88d6-3674dca7d71d",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--ed0957d2-712d-5370-83a6-42e79f1fc0a9",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--f4afae01-d044-5c64-91f7-a7a493299c06",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "C2 check-in endpoint",
            "description": "Contacted by cmd.exe pid 7640 at 2026-03-17T09:18:40Z,
resolved 198.235.24.58:443. Domain VirusTotal 11/89 (2026-09-19).",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[url:value = 'https://goosess.com/read/get.php']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
```

```
            "id": "relationship--a8ec181a-e807-506a-8f94-e23581ca0d96",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--f4afae01-d044-5c64-91f7-a7a493299c06",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "indicator",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "indicator--0ae0fc64-5a83-5d61-a6ab-8eb15c1df370",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "name": "C2 hosting address",
            "description": "Resolution of goosess.com recorded at the time of the beacon.
VirusTotal 12/89, AS396982 Google LLC (2026-09-19).",
            "indicator_types": [
                "malicious-activity"
            ],
            "pattern": "[ipv4-addr:value = '198.235.24.58']",
            "pattern_type": "stix",
            "valid_from": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--a04aaf1b-68f6-5e93-9989-67ff56951ae1",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "indicates",
            "source_ref": "indicator--0ae0fc64-5a83-5d61-a6ab-8eb15c1df370",
            "target_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--f227a552-de0a-5491-b977-2ce128a50d35",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "uses",
            "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "target_ref": "attack-pattern--5e060348-f1ca-56e4-864a-bcee0a12f016",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
```

```
{
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--9146c513-ef8b-5f31-b458-dbdf09c07282",
    "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
    "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--7e28ede3-6f85-529a-976a-3a2dde7ec1df",
    "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
    "object_marking_refs": [
        "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
    ]
},
{
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--f65c3888-023d-5d30-b715-d911c380c7aa",
    "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
    "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--d3186c23-ec14-5cf4-83bc-3030b59ab14b",
    "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
    "object_marking_refs": [
        "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
    ]
},
{
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--855c8ac2-1f07-5411-a28b-e56eda0cc710",
    "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
    "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--17609a65-b597-5661-a45b-a5e2464bac06",
    "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
    "object_marking_refs": [
        "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
    ]
},
{
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--5d9a0757-5347-5cc3-a817-a334353bb41c",
    "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
    "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--c53332c0-7265-5dba-860c-a2ff90ba3678",
    "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
    "object_marking_refs": [
        "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
    ]
},
{
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
```

```
            "id": "relationship--8de4ca9f-169a-5c14-8449-0a3b65aed03d",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "uses",
            "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "target_ref": "attack-pattern--b0676e66-59ed-5936-80ac-2e94d445a570",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        },
        {
            "type": "relationship",
            "spec_version": "2.1",
            "id": "relationship--3bbda533-c901-5c5a-910a-7b5fc7068ebe",
            "created": "2026-03-17T09:02:00.000Z",
            "modified": "2026-09-19T17:00:00.000Z",
            "relationship_type": "uses",
            "source_ref": "malware--1abfa33d-1c6d-5eeb-bffe-dbbb8381d5bf",
            "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a5e52405-94a2-540c-aca4-11ff96c767c4",
            "created_by_ref": "identity--eed6aeea-668d-53de-a717-257af0e51141",
            "object_marking_refs": [
                "marking-definition--94868c89-83c2-464b-929b-a1a8aa3c8487"
            ]
        }
    ]
}
```


8. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Tactic	Technique	ID
Execution	User Execution: Malicious File	T1204.002
Initial Access	Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment	T1566.001
Execution	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell	T1059.001
Defense Evasion	Obfuscated Files or Information	T1027
Persistence, Privilege Escalation	Boot or Logon Autostart Execution: Registry Run Keys	T1547.001
Defense Evasion	Masquerading: Match Legitimate Name or Location	T1036.005
Command and Control	Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols	T1071.001

T1204.002 is the platform's own confirmed answer to the scored classification task. The remaining techniques are stated because each is evidenced directly by one of the four records recovered in the scored tasks — the delivered attachment, the PowerShell command line and its obfuscation, the registry write and its value name, and the outbound connection — rather than inferred from the scenario narrative. This operation's console does not expose an ATT&CK panel of its own.

9. Impact & Containment

Impact: bwl-fin-wks-042 is compromised with persistence installed and an established C2 channel. The host belongs to accounts payable, which makes it a high-value target for invoice fraud and payment redirection specifically — the same access that permits a loader to fetch a second stage also permits the operator to read banking details, supplier correspondence and payment approvals. The persistence survives a reboot and requires no administrator rights, so the machine re-establishes contact on every logon until the Run value is removed. The clerk's credentials and any session held on that host must be treated as exposed. Containment steps, in priority order:

1. Isolate bwl-fin-wks-042 from the network and preserve memory and disk before cleanup; the second stage fetched from the C2 is not identified in the available telemetry.
2. Remove the Run value HKCU\...\Run\svchostno2 and quarantine C:\Users\Public\UHCYbG.cab and C:\Users\Public\49120862.bat after evidence is preserved.
3. Block goosess[.]com and 198.235.24.58 at the proxy, DNS and firewall, and sweep proxy logs for any other host that reached /read/get.php.
4. Reset priya.venkataraman's credentials from a clean device and review payment and supplier-banking changes made from that workstation since 09:11 on 17 March, given the finance role.
5. Search the mail platform for other recipients of invoices-bwlogistics-pay[.]com or of INVOICE_8841.zip and quarantine them; reimage the workstation rather than cleaning it.

10. Conclusion & Recommendations

Final verdict: True Positive. An invoice-themed phishing message from a typosquatted domain failed SPF and DMARC and was delivered anyway; the archive held a Windows shortcut rather than an invoice; running it launched obfuscated PowerShell that staged a script as UHCYbG.cab in C:\Users\Public; a Run value disguised as svchostno2 made the infection survive a reboot; and the same process checked in to goosess[.]com over HTTPS. All 6 scored tasks were resolved from four records across two log sources.

The case is a good illustration of how much can be read from process lineage alone. parent=explorer.exe on that PowerShell process is the single most informative field in the whole incident: it says a human double-clicked something, which immediately separates this from a scheduled task or a service compromise and points the investigation at the mailbox. Add the two locations — C:\Users\Public for staging and HKCU for persistence — and the attacker's constraint becomes clear: they had no administrator rights and did not need them.

Recommendations:

1. Block or quarantine archives containing .lnk files at the mail gateway; a shortcut inside a ZIP has no legitimate business use in invoice correspondence.
2. Quarantine rather than deliver external mail that fails both SPF and DMARC, and flag sender domains that closely resemble the organisation's own.

3. Alert on powershell.exe with a parent of explorer.exe combined with -w hidden or -ep bypass, which is user-initiated script execution and rarely legitimate on a finance workstation.
4. Apply application control to block execution of scripts and executables from C:\Users\Public and other world-writable paths.
5. Monitor writes to HKCU and HKLM Run keys, and alert on value names that imitate Windows components such as svchost, explorer or services.
6. Give accounts-payable workstations tighter egress control and stronger monitoring than general office machines, since they are targeted specifically for payment fraud.

11. Evidence / Screenshots

Figure	Caption	Referenced in
Figure 1	The delivery and execution records: the invoice lure failing SPF and DMARC yet delivered, and powershell.exe starting under explorer.exe with a caret-obfuscated command line reading UHCYbG.cab	Tasks 2, 3, 6
Figure 2	Persistence and command and control: the HKCU Run value svchostno2 pointing at 49120862.bat, then the same cmd.exe process connecting to https://goosess.com/read/get.php on 198.235.24.58:443	Tasks 4, 5
Figure 3	The confirmed finding for the staged first-stage file, with the platform's note on why a payload written to a world-writable directory is a control gap in its own right	Task 3

Figure 1. The delivery and execution records: the invoice lure failing SPF and DMARC yet delivered, and powershell.exe starting under explorer.exe with a caret-obfuscated command line reading UHCYbG.cab.

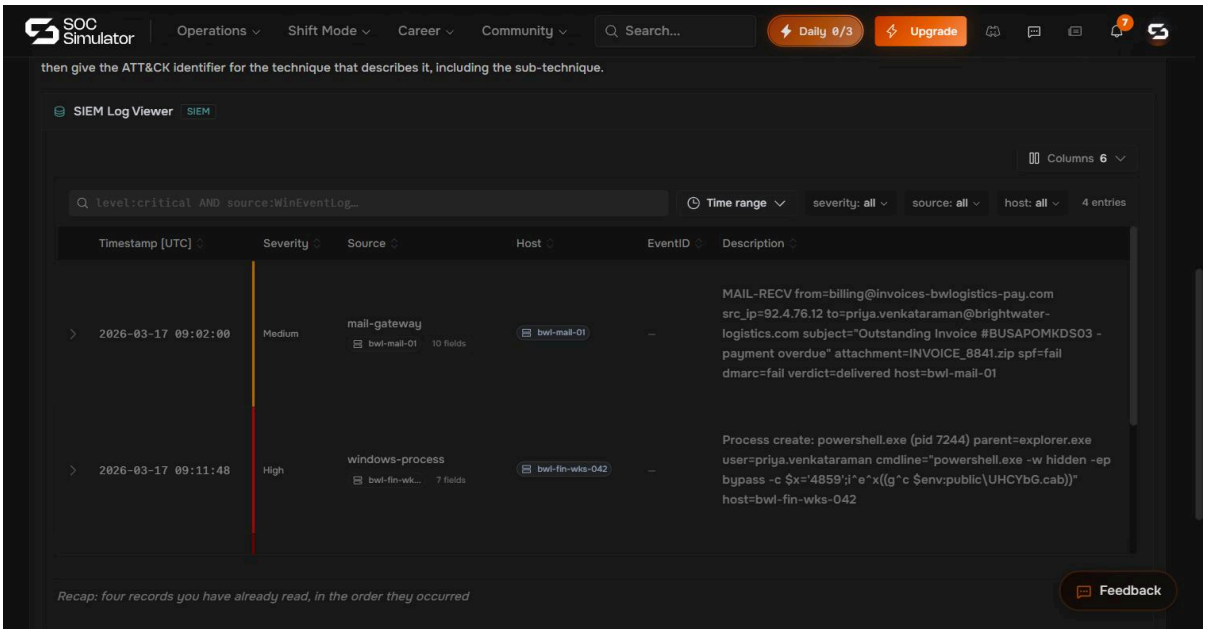


Figure 2. Persistence and command and control: the HKCU Run value svchostno2 pointing at 49120862.bat, then the same cmd.exe process connecting to https://goosess.com/read/get.php on 198.235.24.58:443.

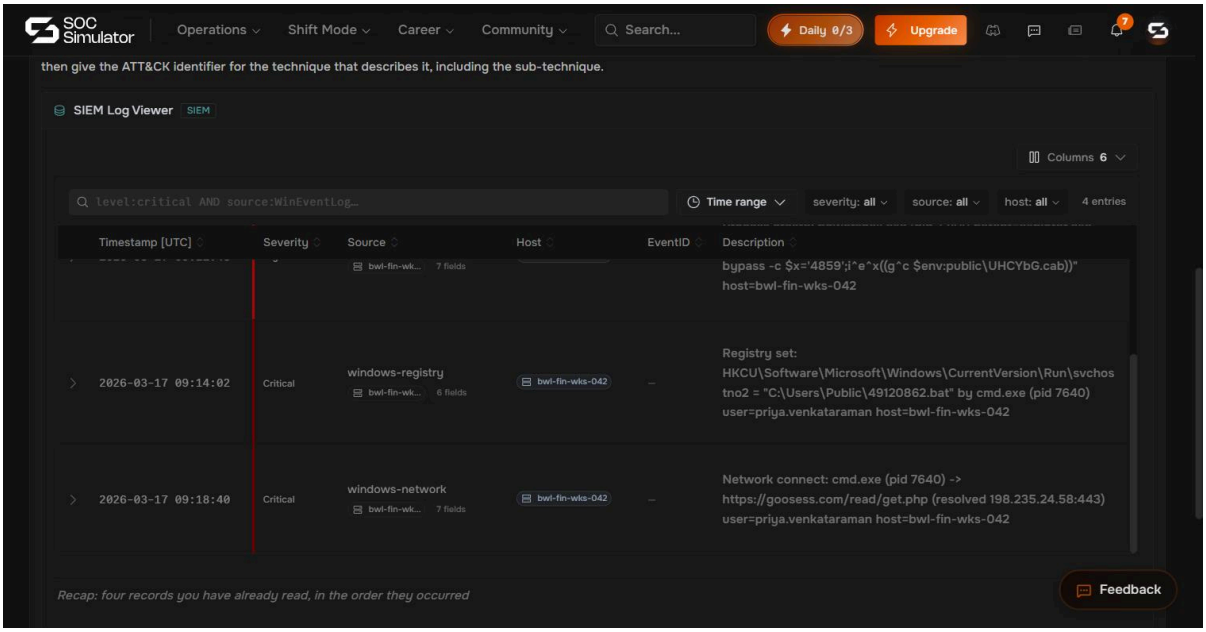


Figure 3. The confirmed finding for the staged first-stage file, with the platform's note on why a payload written to a world-writable directory is a control gap in its own right.

